

What Do Technical Communicators Need to Know about Genre?

SUMMARY

Just as individual members of a language group depend upon every other member's familiarity with the language to facilitate group communication, writers and readers of documents depend upon shared textual conventions, applied in recognizably similar situations, to accomplish their goals. Those shared conventions of text and situation are "genres." Genres can simplify the technical communicator's work by constraining the range of possibilities in a given communication situation, and they can encourage innovation by helping technical communicators understand the goals of a text and envision a range of ways to achieve those goals.

An understanding of genre offers many benefits to the technical communicator. Genres can help technical communicators diagnose a document user's needs and produce documents that respond to those needs in situationally appropriate ways. Since genres arise as successful responses to recurring situations, careful study of a workplace's genres can also help technical communicators perceive how problems are solved and how work gets done in their workplace. Additionally, by understanding a workplace's existing genres, technical communicators can make more informed choices about the need to modify genres (or even to create new ones) in response to emerging workplace situations, technologies, and relationships.

INTRODUCTION

James (not his real name) is an economic development specialist for a county development commission. He helps county businesses with access to the county's private and governmental resources, provides research data for businesses and government agencies, and helps develop new programs to promote economic growth in the county.

James's boss asks him to survey county businesses regarding their resource needs and their satisfaction with the agency's services. His audience includes existing industries, community leaders, economic allies,

and business-service providers. He has been trained as a technical communicator and has some familiarity with writing questionnaires for others, but he has never written a professional report for such a complex audience. He knows that he needs to address that audience, please his boss, and write something that will represent his organization well.

Faced with this new writing situation, how does he begin? In the remainder of this chapter, I consider how technical communicators like James may develop a sense of new writing situations, using an understanding of genres to guide their decision making and problem solving. I begin by summarizing several important developments in modern genre theory, focusing on the principles of social action, typification, choice, change, competence, the correlation of genres, genre systems, and flexibility and originality. The theoretical understanding of genre offers both diagnostic and productive benefits that can help you diagnose communication more effectively and training you to think in terms of larger systems of communication, and how communication operates on the social and cognitive levels.

Based upon these theoretical insights, I provide a set of heuristic questions that new technical communicators can use to diagnose their communication situations as “generic situations” and to develop an effective response. I’ll return to the case of James to see how he can use this heuristic both to prepare an effective report and to improve his understanding of communication and decision making in his workplace.

THE RHETORICAL GENRE APPROACH: A LITERATURE REVIEW

The concept of genre has been around for thousands of years (Aristotle discussed genres in his *Rhetoric*). The most recognized usage of the term describes formal categories of literary or artistic texts: sonnets, plays, mystery novels, country love songs, and so forth. This “formal” approach to genre (that is, this approach that focuses on the form of a text is useful for creating a taxonomy of text types, and even for understanding the relationship between different categories and subcategories of literary texts. (For instance, you could use it to explore the relationship between different kinds of novels: the detective novel, the political thriller, the police procedural all might be considered as species of the genre of mystery novels.)

This formal approach can also be applied to nonliterary texts, of course. For example, in business writing, the genre of the business letter can be identified by a set of formal characteristics; it is generally a typed letter on company letterhead, using a friendly but formal style, and contains the following ordered elements: date, inside address, salutation, purpose statement, introduction, at least one paragraph of body text, conclusion, closing

and signature. The genre of the business letter may also be broken down into several subgenres: good-news letters, bad-news letters, informational letters, cover letters, requests, and so forth. Each of these types of business letter may follow the generic form of the business letter, but also may possess additional identifying characteristics or patterns. For instance, a bad-news letter typically begins with a “buffer” paragraph, followed by a bad-news paragraph, one or more paragraphs of reasons, an optional paragraph with alternatives, and a polite closing.

The formal approach to genre is useful as a strategy for categorizing text types, and even as a source of templates to follow when producing texts. The approach tends to be prescriptive, however, and it oversimplifies the writing situation, making it seem as if a “cookie-cutter” approach to communication is adequate. More importantly, it does little to help us understand how writing is used to achieve specific purposes.

In the past three decades, researchers of rhetoric and technical communication have retooled genre as a [rhetorical concept]. In its rhetorical formulation, genre is seen not as a text type but as what Carolyn Miller (1984) has called a “social action”; or to put it another way, genres are one of the things technical communicators use to fulfill a specific type of purpose within a particular, recognizable, and recurring situation. What’s more, the purpose and situation in question are both “socially situated”—there is a shared community understanding rather than merely an individual definition of the purposes and situations of genres. The community in question might be pretty big (college students) or relatively small (sales staff at the Celltech Company); the point is that members of the community all recognize certain types of communication situations and agree upon what sort of speech or writing would count as an appropriate response to that situation.

Following Miller’s evocative description of genre as social action, the research and theory of genre has blossomed. I won’t describe all of this work here, since much of the work seeks to develop keener analytical and critical tools, as well as keener teaching perspectives, rather than to develop new communication practices. For present purposes, I will focus on the major insights relating to the practice of communication in workplace settings, especially for novices—people who are just learning about their profession, their discipline, or their work setting. And there is much to consider here.

SOCIAL ACTION

First, let’s consider what is meant by “social action” (and why it matters to view genre as a category of social activity rather than a category of tex-

tual form). All communication is social; we're always communicating v
somebody when we write or speak. Even when we don't have a partic
reader in mind, we're writing with at least a loose understanding that
thing we're writing will be read by someone, and that in order for
be understood, we need to relate our intentions to the intentions of
reader.

But admitting that all communication is social isn't the same thin
admitting that genres are social. We need to take one more step. Whe
"communication" encompasses just about any form of symbolic exp
sion between two or more people, genres are what Miller (1984, 24), an
others, describes as typified rhetorical action. By "typified," genr
searchers mean that the participants in a community recognize patt
in their communication forms and the situations in which commu
tion is necessary.

For example, if you're in a classroom setting and your instructor
you to introduce yourself to the class, you are in a typical rhetorical s
tion—one that is recognized by you and the others in the room as a
mon situation in this setting. Even before you say a word, you're al
being acted upon by a genre—the genre of the "class introduction."
do you know what to say? You know because you've been in a similar
ation before, either as a speaker or as a listener. Because the situati
familiar, you can also make some other assumptions about the situa
For instance, among all the many communication possibilities avai
to you, you can assume that you're being asked to produce a certain
specific type of response (a list of unembarrassing personal charac
tics about yourself, beginning with your name, probably including
major, and lasting about ten seconds). In this situation, you recogniz
people would be surprised if you passed around a copy of your résun
if you broke into song. Even if these responses communicated rough
same information, they'd be surprising forms of response (to say the
in this situation. That is, you recognize that your listeners would find
response unsuitable—as a communicative action, it falls outside th
rameters of the genre.

But you also can count on something else. What is "typical" isn't
the form of your response, but also the situation itself. In planning
reply, you can count on the fact that your listeners will recognize th
propriateness of your response in this situation (assuming that y
spond appropriately, that is!). Change a detail of the situation—fr
technical communication class to a performing arts class, for exam
and what counts as an appropriate response (a list, a song) also cha

TYPOIFICATION

What is it that makes any situation typical? There has been a lot of attention to this question. After all, strictly speaking, every situation is unique—you've never before been in that same room with the same instructor, the same group of students, on the same day, at the start of the same class, introducing yourself to those people for the first time. If every situation is strictly unique, then no response is ever truly a response to a "recurring situation," right?

Here's where the notion of typification comes in. According to Merrell and others who have developed this concept, typification is not an individual process of identifying objectively identical situations, but rather a sociocognitive process in which situations come to be treated as examples of a type. Every situation is (in reality) different; what makes them the same is that we see them as the same—and, further, that our method of doing so is shared by others in our social group. After all, if you think you're being asked to give your name and describe your "public self" to your instructor and fellow students, but nobody else in the room perceives the situation in those terms, then you're simply speaking out of turn, not participating in a shared understanding of the situation (that is to say, not employing the correct genre). But if the members of the group are roughly familiar with how this situation works, then collectively the group will "typify" the situation and its responses as part of a recognized genre.

Let's look at a workplace example. Suppose that you're hired as a technical communicator for Celltech, a cell-phone manufacturer. As your first assignment, you're asked to write a "quick-start" sheet for unpacking a new phone, installing the battery, hooking up the charger. You dutifully complete your desk, tinker around with the product until you're comfortable with how to perform the tasks, and then write up a list of the steps that you followed. You make some line drawings illustrating various steps, and when you arrange the text and illustrations on the page, you give the document a once-over, and then you submit the completed list to your boss: mission accomplished. The boss takes one look at the result and says, "That's right—the procedure might work, but it's not a quick-start guide. It has too many steps, and it makes the product look too complicated. Plus, where did you get these pictures? That's why we have a graphics department."

What went wrong here isn't that your text failed; rather, the text was not recognized as an appropriate response within the specific rhetorical situation that you were responding to. After all, you weren't writing instructions in a vacuum; you were writing them in a specific context (Celltech's

to be consumed by specific sets of readers (Celltech's customers, but your supervisor and other members of the Celltech community).

How might you approach this situation differently? First, you'd inform yourself about how quick-start sheets are written at Celltech. You'd study the genre, along with the variations that tend to meet the needs of a specific circumstance, however idiosyncratic they may be. For example, after reviewing several other instruction sets, you might discover that some of these documents use photos instead of line drawings, positioned in the same way on the page; they all use more or less the same verbal style, which is formal but friendly, with all instructional steps numbered and written as imperative statements. (You judge that these are firm genre conventions in this writing situation.) But there are variations in other features. The length of the instructions sometimes varies considerably from product to another. The text under each numbered instruction is a longer description in some cases, but shorter (or altogether absent) in others. Some products use two-color illustrations; others are printed in black and white. These variables, you judge, are less firm, indicating either that the technical communicator is free to play with these variables, or that there may be some underlying pattern corresponding to these differences. You see a pattern that you would need to figure out through further investigation.

In producing a quick-start guide for your company's product, you're not just writing a lone document. You are performing a well-defined, recurring social act that is recognizable to the other members of the community that you've just joined. In a very real way, it's the whole community that is producing these instructions (by regulating what counts as the "right way to do it," among all the other possible ways), not you as an individual technical communicator. But by performing this social act, you're also identifying yourself as a participant in the group—someone who recognizes the recurrent situations that determine work in this situation, and who can make effective choices about how to respond to those situations in socially valid ways.

GENRE AND CHOICE

The next major insight of recent work on genre has to do with the idea of choice. The formal view treats genres almost as if they were templates: do x, y, and z, and you've written a business letter or an instruction sheet. I call it the "Mad Libs" version of genre. Even the "genre as social act" view tends to suggest that writers engage in patterned, determinate writing instead of the form predetermining what they write, it's the social situation—the social exigency—that determines the writers' actions.

Yet experience tells us that we generally have lots of options—what

write is not predetermined, and the work of a writer is the work of making effective choices. Many researchers of genre have sought to reconcile this contradiction by examining how genres actually operate in real-world workplace situations.

What they have found is that the power of genres is at once constraining and liberating. As Susan Katz puts it, “[genre conventions] constrain writers by limiting the form, style, language, and content that are appropriate in particular situations. Conversely, conventions enable by supplying templates, genres, and topics which can be useful to the writer at all stages of the writing process” (quoted in Artemeva 2006a, 23). Genre is constraining because the genre situation imposes certain limits upon the writer’s approach (if I’m writing a business letter, I can’t generally do it in iambic pentameter; if I’m writing a sit-com episode, I generally can’t kill off the protagonist at the end of the episode). But genre is enabling because it gives me a place to start, both topically and structurally, allowing me to be creative within the scope of the genre’s limits. If I’m writing a business letter, I don’t need to decide how the letter should be formatted or what voice to use; I can focus on the best ways to present my argument. If I’m writing a quick-start guide, I can depend upon some of the conventions and expectations that the genre already provides. With those decisions already made, I can focus on details like the optimal order of steps and how much to write about each step, within the limits that the genre affords.

Moreover, if I’m convinced that the standard approach isn’t the best approach for some reason, I can dream up unconventional approaches that may still qualify as examples of the genre in question. To adapt a metaphor from jazz music, the genre provides the theme and the structure, but allows the musician some room to play variations upon that theme as long as those variations remain rooted in the theme and structure of the piece. As a writer, I may decide that some aspect of my rhetorical situation calls for a lighter tone, less formal style, more elaborate explanation, or a different type of illustration than is typical of the genre. If I vary some aspect of my approach, I risk losing the familiarity that readers depend upon when they read texts in this genre. But if I make limited strategic changes, and if I do so with specific purposes in mind, then I can carry my readers with me. The familiar features and content, and the familiar communication situation itself, will help them interpret the unfamiliar bits properly.

GENRE AND CHANGE

This notion of choice helps us also to understand how genres evolve in response to new circumstances. As Schryer (1993, 200) notes, genres are

absolutely “stable” or fixed. Rather, they are “stabilized-for-now,” always subject to the pressures of changing situations, new writers and readers, and new content. Fortunately, it’s pretty rare for every aspect of some communication situation in a given community to change all at once. But as conditions change, as technology provides communicators with new tools, and as new people enter and become experts in a community, so too do the community’s genres change.

The above description of variations in genres suggests one mechanism for this change: individual variations that are responses to individual situations, if repeated in similar situations, can become just as much identified with the genre as were the supposedly “fixed” conventions that they supplanted. Berkenkotter and Huckin (1995, 6) observe that these changes are driven by situational differences as well as individuals’ unique responses to the changing world, ensuring that genres are “always sites of contention between stability and change . . . [t]hey are inherently dynamic, constantly (if gradually) changing over time in response to the sociocognitive needs of individual users.”

Researchers of genre have studied how genres change over time and discovered many instances of this process at work. For instance, Charles Bazerman (1988) and Dwight Atkinson (1999), looking at the genre of the scientific research article in different periods, discovered that several characteristics of this genre have changed, even though at no time did members of the communities in question ever declare the need for a change. The changes were incremental and situational, and they’re only visible in retrospect: the discussion of methods becomes more prominent, the use of mathematical data increases, the voice shifts from first-person to third-person and from active to passive, and so on.

Why is this important? As a technical communicator, you need to be adept at recognizing just what parts of the genre can be budged and which are relatively fixed. Going back to the example of the business letter: some elements (such as the date, the salutation, and the courteous, professional style) are comparatively fixed (or, in Schryer’s term, “stabilized-for-now”). If you wrote a business letter using slang or sentence fragments, our readers would doubt your competency as a member of the “social group” of professionals in the business environment—your text might be read as a failed attempt at a business letter. If you left out the salutation, readers might not even recognize your text as a business letter at all—in terms of its rhetorical situation, it would be unintelligible (and therefore it would fail to respond to the rhetorical situation).

Yet, other elements within the business letter genre are less fixed. For instance, most business letters span multiple paragraphs, but you could

write a successful letter that consists of only one paragraph (or even a sentence); it might be seen as unusual, but it wouldn't be rejected. Likewise, if you were writing to a business associate with whom you also have a personal relationship, you might opt for a more casual or personal tone. Or if one of your intentions is to encourage a stronger personal connection with a business associate, you might strategically employ elements of personal correspondence, stretching the business-letter conventions to achieve an unconventional purpose. Whereas questions about a recipient's family members or private life would generally be outside the scope of the business-letter genre (at least in current American business settings), the particular situation often calls for variations upon the usual theme. There are many conventions within a stable genre, but no absolute rules.

GENRE AND COMPETENCE

This flexibility matters a great deal when it comes to expressing yourself as a competent user of a genre, for, as Artemeva (2006a, 23) observes, the better our command of genres, the more flexibility and freedom we can apply in using genres and the more fully we can express our creativity. Thus, even when acting recurrently in a recurrent situation, we can still express one's individuality when using a fully mastered genre. By knowing the boundaries (soft and hard), you can more comfortably stretch those boundaries when it's necessary to do so. Conversely, realize and recognize that those writers who are the most versatile users of a genre are also the most competent. So not only does your increasing competence enable you to use genres more flexibly, but your fluid and flexible use of genres—your ability to strike the right notes with the genre—is a sign of your competence in that social situation.

As a newcomer to a work environment, you will naturally want to demonstrate competence. The effective use of that workplace's genres is an important way to do so. Competence is more than technical skill, content knowledge, or error prevention; it is also a matter of awareness, planning, and judgment. Novice users of workplace genres tend to make two types of error. First, they make missteps that are the product of incomplete understanding of how the genre operates in its specific context (say, not understanding the difference between a situation calling for a memo and one calling for a letter). Second, even when they perform properly, they tend to stick with the safest (that is to say, the most comfortable) variations of the genre—they take fewer risks, because they're uncomfortable deciding just how far they can play with the genre. To a tennis metaphor, they don't aim for the lines as much. As their un-

tanding of the genre and its situation grows, so too does their willingness to employ more of the genre's flexibility.

CORRELATION OF GENRES

So far the discussion has focused on genres as discrete entities. But, especially since the mid-1990s, genre researchers have become increasingly attentive to how genres work in combination, and how genres relate to the various roles played by members of a workplace or social group.

As early as the 1950s, long before the boom in English-language scholarship along these lines, Russian scholar Mikhail Bakhtin (1986) noted that every instance of communication is an utterance in response to previous utterances, and anticipating future utterances. Genres are not employed in isolation; all utterances (that is, all instances of speaking or writing) are in a sense *responses* to some prior utterance, and they instigate some sort of response, which itself instigates another response, and so on. The "rules" governing the appropriate types of response are genre rules; utterances of a genre tend to be made in particular, regularized patterns of relationship, and these patterns themselves reflect the relationships within the rhetorical community (e.g., workplace) in which they occur.

For example, if a friend gives you an insult, you have a limited number of conventionalized genres available to respond. You could respond with another insult, a joke, an angry retort, a defamation suit, or a punch in the nose (but not a purchase order, an anniversary toast, or a résumé). The punch in the nose could yield a return in kind, an apology, a curse, or a lawsuit. These conventionalized responses are not suitable merely because some "rule set" stipulates them. Rather, they're suitable because they *mean* something specific and conventional within the context and community in which they're used. To respond to an insult with a defamation suit might be interpreted negatively (as an overreaction, perhaps), but it would at least carry meaning. To respond with a résumé, on the other hand, would simply be unintelligible.

Thus genres are not merely standardized containers of message content. Genres establish, articulate, and reinforce socially recognized relationships, and these relationships play a role in how the content of messages is understood. Just as the shape, size, and design of a document often can prepare readers for the content within (helping a reader know whether to expect a novel, a shopping list, or a progress report), so too does genre cue readers' understanding of the social and structural relationships that workplace communication depends upon. Consider business correspondence. Business letters are often written in response to previous utterances (a prior letter, an advertisement, a phone call), and

they provide other typical generic responses. A check letter will prompt a letter of reply (either informational, good news, news). A good-news letter may prompt a thank-you letter or an assistance letter. The exchange of letters coincides with, and depends on the social relationship between (in this example) a company and its clients.

GENRE SYSTEMS

Beyond the basic notion that genres are interrelated (and that they follow the conventionalized relationship patterns of rhetorical communities), there have been several specific models proposed for understanding the correlation of genres. Genre researchers have used various terms, including genre sets (Devitt 1991, 2004), genre systems (Bazerman 1994; Rorty 1997; Yates and Orlikowski 2002), genre repertoires (Orlikowski and Yates 1994), and genre ecologies (Spinuzzi and Zachry 2000; Spinuzzi 2004) to describe these interrelationships (cf. also Spinuzzi 2004; Artemeva 2005: 25–27). These concepts differ somewhat in their details, but they all endorse the notion that participants in a rhetorical community engage in recurrent, typified interactions using multiple, related genres. Consider these examples.

- Your boss sends out a memo calling for applications to head a new division of your company. This conventionalized genre—the call for applications—propagates a similarly conventionalized response—the letter of application.
- A government agency issues a request for bids on a new information technology services contract. Your IT services company responds to this request for bids by submitting a bid. (Leading up to that bid, other internal genres might also be used; for instance, memos, phone calls, strategic plans, recommendation reports, and other genres may be circulated, all resulting in the bid itself.)
- A customer writes a letter of complaint about a product manufactured by your company. The letter is delivered to your desk. First, you evaluate the complaint (perhaps by talking with a technical support specialist or reading reports of past complaints about the product). Based upon your evaluation, you reply to the customer using one of several possible conventionalized responses: a letter of correction or apology; a refund; an explanation that may or may not assign responsibility to the customer, the shipper, or some other party for the failure; or perhaps a query, asking for more information about the complaint. Additionally, you may file internal

documentation reporting on the problem and its solution. If you discover that the problem is significant and affects other products or customers, you may need to compose additional messages as well, possibly even recommending a product recall or reporting the problem to an internal quality-control department or external agency, depending upon the scope of the problem.

As these examples demonstrate, certain genres propagate certain other genres in predictable patterns. These genres don't simply structure messages; they engage in work—going back to Miller's germinal insight, they are forms of social *action*, the way an organization gets things done. As a new member of the community, you are tasked with learning not only how to produce whatever individual genres are common in your position but also when to produce them—in response to what events or signals.

Spinuzzi's concept of "genre ecologies" builds upon these other types of assemblage; in Spinuzzi's formulation, however, the interwoven genres in any workplace or activity network "are not simply performed or communicated, they represent the 'thinking out' of a community as it cyclically performs an activity" (Spinuzzi 2004, 114). Moreover, genres actually *mediate* (Spinuzzi's word is "mediate") the nature of the activity itself; that is, the activity is fundamentally shaped by the nature of the genres that enact it, such that it is impossible to separate the social activity (say, fulfilling purchase orders) from the genres (the purchase order) that one uses to do that activity. The act of fulfilling an order is encoded in the "purchase order" form, and conversely, the form structures the act.

This notion of mediation elevates genres to the same level of importance (or agency) as the people who use them. Though people act through genres (for instance, by writing reports to influence a supervisor's decision making), genres also shape or "mediate" people and their activities—creating a system of authorized ways of doing things—ways that create certain possibilities for individual action, that foreclose other possibilities, and that even create and foreclose certain types of intentions. For example, within a genre ecology that includes various genres for lodging complaints or expressing dissatisfaction, certain activities associated with dissent are enabled and regulated—they're written into specific social relationships and communication modes. Within a genre ecology that does not offer customary genres for complaint, people either cannot participate in that activity, or, if they're sufficiently motivated, they are forced to employ existing genres in unconventional or illegitimate ways (such as whistle-blowing)—ways that defy the social relationships of the group and that may cause disequilibrium in the genre ecology.

GENRE, FLEXIBILITY, AND ORIGINALITY

This account of genres propagating other genres and fitting together to reflect a social structure may make it seem as if technical communication is a purely mechanical process: standard letters come in; standard responses go out; standard forms are filed, calls made, and so forth. But there remains a great demand for invention, judgment, and creativity in how writers actually use genres. Each situation may call for certain distinct types of response, but each response is nevertheless unique.

Earlier we considered how genres invite writers to make choices within a set of genre constraints; as Katz suggested, these constraints can actually help writers move forward by limiting the number of choices that need to be made in any given situation. Schryer (2000, 2002) goes far in arguing that working within a genre is an improvisation; communicators draw upon the conventions of genre as strategic resources that allow them to strike certain socially recognized notes (cf. Artemeva 2006a). But from situation to situation, different decisions will be made, different judgments called for, different notes struck; ever-changing circumstances mean that our genre-based messages will change as well. In fact, genres are never truly stable; they are, to return to Schryer's (1993, 200) oft-quoted phrase, only "stabilized-for-now." They evolve in response to changing purposes, content, participants, and technologies. They can evolve because those who use them are continually improvising—making situation-specific changes in their performance of the genres, drawing upon strategies that they have learned from other genres and settings, and, in some cases, flouting the conventions of the genre for strategic purposes.

Much of the genre research of the past decade has reported on various forms of genre change: writers' uses of novel rhetorical strategies, new, emergent, or hybrid genres in the face of new rhetorical problems (for instance, Artemeva 2006b; Bazerman 1988; Freedman 2006; Heath 2004; Yates 1989). In some cases, this genre change or hybridization may be a strategic effort to overcome the structural limitations of a rhetorical situation; Wendy Sharer (2003, 8) uses the term "genre work" to describe the "strategic blending of typified and innovative textual elements" that tended to explicitly adapt the genre resources of privileged communities to a new set of purposes for which no effective genres exist.

New professionals (and people in new professional situations or identities) must be aware of the stability of the genres that they're expected to use in their work settings, but they must also be conscious of their flexibility—in other words, they should understand genres as resources to support strategic improvisation. Likewise, technical communication

need some understanding of how their workplace genres have evolved and how they might evolve in the future. Not every writing task is the right moment to innovate, but often it's possible to alter the expected pattern of communication in order to solve problems.

HEURISTIC: UNDERSTANDING AND USING GENRES IN YOUR WORKPLACE

So how do you learn the genres of your workplace? How do you use genres once you've learned them? What can your knowledge of genres tell about your workplace? As noted above, genres provide a kind of shorthand for professionals. If you're familiar with the basic set of genres typical of your workplace, including how and when they're used, you can rely upon those genres to simplify many everyday decisions. Knowing to use a particular genre doesn't eliminate all of the decisions that you'll need to make, of course, but it takes some variables out of the equation, giving you a starting point for engaging in the routine behavior of daily professional activities in your workplace.

The major theoretical perspectives on genre introduced above suggest a number of questions that we can bring to bear upon technical communication in the workplace. So let's turn now to another genre, the heuristic—a set of questions and tips that adapt the theoretical material above into a useful guide as you begin to use new workplace genres. I've grouped these heuristic questions into four categories: relationships, purpose, document characteristics, and learning. In each category, I offer questions designed to help you examine technical communication tasks and situations using the tools of genre. This heuristic can help not only when you are writing or speaking, but also when you're the recipient of workplace messages. As workplace-situated tools, genres can help you make sense of your work site just as they can help you participate in it.

CATEGORY 1: GENRE AND PURPOSE

The literature review discusses genre as one of the resources that technical communicators use to respond to rhetorical situations, and one of the key characteristics of any rhetorical situation is purpose—the communicator's purpose in creating a message and the recipient's purpose in reading or hearing (or, more broadly, doing something with) that message. The first set of questions that you should ask about any situation involving technical communication genres is about purposes:

- What is the primary purpose of this genre? What result is it intended to achieve: a decision, an action or event, a reply, a

change in understanding or perspective? Remember that genres are not just document types—they are types of *action* intended to produce a result. What result typically ensues (and what is typically intended) when this genre is used?

- Does the genre have any secondary purposes? In addition to the direct outcomes intended for the work, consider what other outcomes, including relationship outcomes, your organization might be hoping for. For example, some messages have the direct purpose of informing but also the indirect purpose of establishing connections or promoting an organization's credibility.

CATEGORY 2: GENRE AND RELATIONSHIPS

Genres aren't simply interchangeable tools that anyone can use in any circumstance; rather, they reflect existing relationships between message creators and recipients. In some ways, genres even help to create those relationships, signaling how the participants in a dialogue should act with regard to one another. The second set of heuristic questions prompts you to consider the relational dimensions of genre. When you are faced with a communication situation, ask the following questions:

- What is my relationship to my audience or audiences, and what sorts of communication are typical in this relationship? Who are the players in this genre? Who normally writes it and who normally reads it?
- Do any others participate in some way (e.g., by contributing data or providing feedback)? What responsibilities are mine as the writer, and what responsibilities are shared with others (e.g., subject-matter experts, information providers, document designers, graphic artists, supervisors, or editors)?
- Where does the genre fit within the "genre system" or "genre ecology" of your workplace? Does it explicitly respond to other, initiating genres? Does it call for specific (either explicit or implicit) genres of response? Is there a range of possible appropriate responses?
- What else can I learn from the genre about the relationship that exists between these participants? Is the relationship hierarchical or nonhierarchical? Do the people involved have similar or different goals or concerns—are they collaborating? Disagreeing? Competing? Do they know each other or not? Is the relationship short-term or persistent?

EGORY 3: GENRE AND DOCUMENT CHARACTERISTICS

though contemporary genre theory considers rhetorical features more than form, the formal and stylistic characteristics of documents are nonetheless important clues to help us understand and use genres. Ask the following questions regarding the formal and stylistic characteristics of the genres you need to use:

Are the documents in this genre durable or ephemeral? Are they filed, bound, shelved, or otherwise stored, or are they read and then discarded? Why? What does this fact suggest about the relational or rhetorical aspects of the genre? What does it suggest about how the document should be produced?

Are documents in this genre read through in their entirety, or are they sampled piece by piece or section by section? Consider what the text structure reveals about how the text is meant to be read. Text structure often reflects reading behavior. For example, texts that have lots of clearly marked sections, heavy labeling, navigational tools (like indexes or tables of contents), or a “modular” feel are designed to support sampling/reference rather than cover-to-cover reading.

If you have access to multiple examples of this genre, what variations (of structure, size, style, content, arrangement, or other elements) do you observe? Consider possible explanations for these variations. What seem to be the limits to these variations?

What characteristics (of structure, size, style, content, or other elements) seem to be the most stable or “required” in this genre? Remember that genres regulate the choices available to you, but that writers have a great deal of flexibility in how they fulfill the expectations of the genre.

EGORY 4: LEARNING GENRES

By the time you are in your career, you will spend much of your time learning to identify and use new genres, and all of the heuristic questions above will help you make the transition from novice to expert user of technical communication genres in your workplace. I’ll end this section with a couple additional heuristic questions to help you in this learning process.

Does your workplace provide written instructions or templates to help people write this genre, or do you have models from which you can work? Ask around; how did others in your workplace learn to use this genre? Collect copies of typical documents (electronic

copies if possible), so that you can see your organization's genre conventions in action.

- Are there any "analogues"—similar, but more familiar genres that you can adapt to your purposes? What familiar genres does this one resemble, in form, content, medium, or purpose? Consider whether this genre is a version of something more familiar to you or whether some of the same writing strategies could be applied in this genre. Even if this genre is distinct in some ways, your experience using other genres may help you make choices in this one. Be aware of the differences, but also exploit the similarities.

EXTENDED EXAMPLE:

THE CASE OF JAMES, COUNTY DEVELOPMENT COMMISSION

Let's see how this heuristic works by returning to the real-world technical communication case introduced earlier. A communicator's decision-making process is rarely simple or linear, and not all of the heuristic questions will be equally relevant to every writing task. But as you'll see, the heuristic questions can help you make effective strategic choices about your writing tasks, based upon clues from your workplace and your prior experience with other genres.

As you may remember, James is a new technical communicator working on economic development for a county development commission. His boss asked him to conduct a survey of county businesses regarding their source needs and their satisfaction with his agency's services, and then share the results in a written report. James conducted the survey, then considered the data and reflected upon his technical communication task.

First of all, he considered the purposes of this report. The primary purpose stated in his boss's instruction was clear: to report information about the state of business in the county over the past year. The document therefore needed to represent the data that he collected as clearly as possible. The report was not necessarily intended to instigate specific actions, but its information might help businesses make more informed decisions in the future.

Although he had never written a report like this one, James knew that his boss had been collecting and reporting these data annually for several years. So, rather than start from scratch, James began by looking at samples from the previous four years. These samples, along with his boss's instructions, revealed to him that the report's purpose was more complicated than simply to report data. He was also informing stakeholders (primarily representatives of the local business community) about the